

CLIENT STORY

AI Recommended First, Google Second: A Woodbury Agent's First 6 Months

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Most visibility plans chase Google rankings first and hope AI follows. This Twin Cities agent did the opposite — and became the AI-recommended source for every tracked local topic months before Google traffic broke out. Here is the documented sequence, including the modest early numbers.

Quick Answer

An independent agent in Woodbury, MN began a HeyPearl engagement with zero Google reviews, 88 Facebook followers, and a site that had not yet appeared in organic search, competing against agents holding 200–400 reviews. The engagement deliberately sequenced AI visibility first. By month 4, the agent was the #1 AI-recommended source across all 5 tracked Woodbury topics with 76.7% positive AI sentiment; by month 5, website health had reached 93/100 and Google reviews had grown from 0 to 19 at 5.0 stars. Classic search visibility followed: in month 6 (August), Google Search impressions grew 822% (1,150 to 10,600) and clicks grew 179% (24 to 67). The results are documented and anonymized as 'The Woodbury Agent' on HeyPearl's public case studies and Recent Wins pages.

A competitive suburb and a very small starting point

Woodbury is a growing Twin Cities suburb with an established real estate market, and the agents already working it hold the kind of advantages that are hard to out-build quickly: hundreds of Google reviews and years of domain authority. This agent began a HeyPearl engagement with 88 Facebook followers, 108 Instagram followers, zero Google reviews, and a website that had not yet appeared in organic search.

Competing head-on for Google rankings against agents with 200 to 400 reviews would have meant a long wait with little visible progress. The plan took a different route, and the route is the story.

The decision: AI visibility first

The standard playbook builds Google visibility first and treats AI visibility as a byproduct. This engagement reversed the order on purpose. The reasoning was simple: AI engines evaluating who to recommend weigh entity clarity, structured data, topical depth, and corroborating signals. A new site can earn those faster than it can out-rank agents with years of accumulated Google authority. So the first phase focused on being clearly and accurately understood by AI engines, with the expectation that organic search and local pack visibility would compound behind it.

That is a trade-off, not a free lunch. It meant the early Google numbers stayed small while the AI numbers moved.

Months one to three: small signals, in the right places

The early data was modest, and it is worth reading that way. At day 43, Google Business Profile impressions tripled month over month (54 to 161), with the first 10 website clicks coming from the profile, and Instagram reach hit 599 — 5.5 times the follower count. At day 73, the site recorded its first 126 website sessions, with a 4m 42s average session time and the contact page accounting for 17% of all pageviews, a strong high-intent signal for a site that small. By day 104, Business Profile impressions peaked at 251, up 365% from 54 at activation, and a first seller-focused blog post began driving early organic traffic.

None of these are large numbers. They are the early signs of a presence coming online, and the contact page share suggests the few visitors who arrived were serious.

Month four: the AI recommendation lands

By day 134, the agent was the #1 AI-recommended source across all 5 tracked Woodbury local real estate topics, with 76.7% positive AI sentiment and 31 new AI citations identified in a single month. In the same period, 990 technical issues had been resolved, site health reached 69 out of 100 from zero, the site expanded from 100 to 117 pages, and 18 Google reviews were on file.

This is the payoff of the sequence: a newcomer with a fraction of the incumbents' review count was nonetheless the top recommendation when AI engines were asked about the local market.

Month five: a foundation that holds

By day 165, website health reached 93 out of 100 and the site had its best month yet — 204 sessions, up 63% over the prior month, with organic search sessions averaging 4m 05s of engagement. Authority backlinks had grown to more than 500 across 144 referring domains. Google reviews reached 19 at a perfect 5.0 stars, built through a concentrated review campaign.

The agent's own summary of this stage was that the foundation was something they had not known they needed: top recommendation on AI search in Woodbury, site health at 93%, and a wall of five-star reviews, all within five months.

Month six: Google catches up

Then the order of events paid off in the second direction. By day 196, Google Search impressions grew 822% month over month (1,150 to 10,600) and clicks grew 179% (24 to 67), driven by a wave of newly published local content: a Woodbury school-district guide earned 957 impressions in its first month live, a new Minnesota-summer relocation FAQ added 491, and a utilities and services relocation guide added 423. Google Business Profile interactions edged up 9.7% to 34, with a 5.0-star rating across 20 reviews.

Note the honest scale: 67 clicks is a small absolute number. The meaningful signal is the direction and the source — 10,600 impressions from pages that did not exist a month earlier.

What the sequence teaches

Three lessons stand out. First, in a market dominated by incumbents with large review counts, AI recommendation can be reached before Google rankings, because the two engines weigh different evidence. Second, the early period will look underwhelming on Google metrics, and that is the expected cost of this sequencing rather than a sign it is not working. Third, the AI foundation does not stay separate: the entity clarity, structured data, and topical content built for AI engines are the same assets that later fed Google's impressions.

Who this sequencing fits

If you are entering a market where established competitors hold large review counts and years of authority, and you cannot afford to wait a year for Google to notice you, leading with AI visibility is a reasonable strategy. If you already hold strong Google rankings, the order matters less, and the work is more about making sure AI engines represent you accurately.

Frequently Asked Questions

Is this a real client, or a composite example?

This is a real, documented engagement. The client's real name is not used publicly — HeyPearl anonymizes client case studies with a hyperlocal identity label, in this case 'The Woodbury Agent' — but the metrics in this article match the figures published on HeyPearl's case studies and Recent Wins pages, sourced from Google Search Console, Google Analytics, Google Business Profile, and AI visibility monitoring data.

Why lead with AI visibility instead of Google rankings?

Because the local competitors held 200 to 400 reviews and years of Google authority, which are slow to overcome. AI engines weigh different evidence, such as entity clarity, structured data, and topical depth, which a new site can build faster. The plan expected Google visibility to compound behind the AI foundation, and by month six it did.

Did Google results stay small for a long time?

Yes, and that is the honest trade-off of this sequencing. Through the first several months, website sessions and Business Profile numbers were modest. The larger Google gain showed up in month six, when search impressions grew 822% from 1,150 to 10,600, though clicks were still a small absolute number at 67.

How long did it take to become the #1 AI-recommended source?

About four months. By day 134 the agent was the #1 AI-recommended source across all 5 tracked Woodbury local real estate topics, with 76.7% positive AI sentiment and 31 new AI citations identified in a single month.

Would this sequence work in any market?

It fits best where incumbents hold large review counts and long-standing Google authority. In a market where you already rank well, the order matters less. Results also vary by competition, starting point, and scope, so treat this as

one documented example rather than a guarantee.

CONCLUSION

When incumbents hold hundreds of reviews and years of authority, waiting to out-rank them on Google is a slow bet. This Woodbury agent led with AI visibility instead, became the #1 AI-recommended source for every tracked local topic within about four months, and then watched Google impressions grow 822% in month six as the same foundation fed classic search. The early Google numbers were small, and the sequence still worked.
